

Plagiarism Detection and Consequences Policy

1. Definition of Plagiarism

Plagiarism at Westbrook University includes, but is not limited to: verbatim copying of text without quotation marks and citation; paraphrasing another's ideas without attribution; presenting another student's submitted work as one's own; and submitting text generated by artificial intelligence tools without instructor authorization and disclosure.

2. Detection Methods

All written submissions in courses using the university LMS are automatically scanned by Turnitin, the university's plagiarism detection platform. Turnitin generates a similarity report that instructors review. A high similarity score triggers an instructor review but does not automatically constitute a finding of plagiarism — proper citation of sources is expected and similarity from quotations is normal.

Instructors may also use manual review, database searches, and source verification when they suspect plagiarism.

3. Consequences by Severity

3.1 Minor Plagiarism (first offense, unintentional)

Grade of zero on the affected assignment, required plagiarism education workshop, and a formal written warning placed in the student's academic integrity file.

3.2 Significant Plagiarism (substantial portion of assignment or intentional)

Automatic F for the course, academic integrity file notation, and referral to the Academic Integrity Office for further review.

3.3 Aggravated Plagiarism (thesis, capstone, or repeated offense)

Academic suspension for at least one semester, permanent academic integrity file notation, and potential academic dismissal. Degree conferral may be withheld pending investigation.

4. Student Rights in Plagiarism Cases

Before any sanction is finalized, students are given written notice of the allegation and an opportunity to respond. Students may contest a plagiarism finding through the Academic Integrity Office's review process. Appeals are governed by ACAD-INT-001 and the Disciplinary Appeals Guidelines (STUD-DIS-003).

